Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Jon Hendricks
Part II

Vocalese master Jon Hendricks celebrated the millennium by revisiting his musical past and creating a legacy for the future. A reunion with Annie Ross at New York's Blue Note brought rave reviews and a validation of their lasting contribution to American music. Jon is also preparing to launch the first collegiate program to teach the art of vocalese at the University of Toledo. In addition to being an articulate spokesperson for jazz, Jon is a man of wide ranging interests. He offered his opinions on religion, health care, politics, music and the human race during this second interview for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

Part II was conducted in New York City by Monk Rowe on January 29, 2000.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Manhattan today and I am very pleased to have, for the second time, my guest Jon Hendricks, the inventor of vocalese. And I'm going to pin you down momentarily on your definition. And you look great by the way.

JH: Thank you very much.

MR: In your sartorial splendor, which is one of your phrases. Do you have a secret to staying fit and young?

JH: If it is a secret I don't know exactly what it is except that I'm always interested in life itself. I'm interested in everything. My patron is Francis Bacon, who said, "I take the world for my purview." In other words his study is everything. And that's the way I am. I'm interested in everything. So when I wake up in the morning it's like a child waking up in a garden. Everything is here and I'm interested in it, whatever it is.

MR: So you're not just totally a music-oriented person.

JH: Never was. No. I've always had a literary side to me. I got the only A in my Creative Writing class in seven years. The professor, Dr. Milton Marks, wrote the textbook that was used in Harvard, Yale, Princeton, all the universities. And he hadn't given an A in seven years. And he gave me one. And I got the only A in my speech class in four years. And I was a history minor and I got all A's in that. So I've always been interested in several other things — like I say, everything else. I was interested in everything. I was going to be a doctor originally. I was going to study medicine. Because I'm interested in medicine, from the standpoint of Hippocrates and Paracelsus. You know, real medicine. Because I think the medical profession today is not even medicine. It's just drug pushing raised to a dignified socially accepted position. It's not healing. Nobody heals anything. The average surgeon, his way of making a cure is to cut the thing off or out. That's not medicine. That's butchering. When you consider Hippocrates, who is the father of

medicine, he never operated on anybody, and treated nervous disorders with higher mathematics. Because numbers quiet the nervous system. Because numbers are what everything is made of. There's a book in the Bible called "Numbers." So if you get interested in the numerical aspect of anything, your nerves quiet down. This is medicine.

MR: So you'd be a believer in what we call alternative medicine?

JH: Alternative medicine is the tip of the iceberg. Every doctor of any consequence would be a dietician. Because that's the root of all sickness. The wrong foods that we put into our bodies. They make us sick. And it's ridiculous to talk of keeping people healthy while you're selling them the very food that's making them sick. That's cold. Medicine has got to change, and I think it will in this new millennium. I think a new millennium is a cosmic changing. It wipes out the old and starts a new structure. I think we're seeing that happen. Politically — I called the election in England that put the Labor Party into power. Everybody thought I was nuts. I called the election in France that put the Socialists predominantly in the Senate, although Chirac remains President, but he's a figurehead, because the Socialists have the most seats. And Lionel Jospin runs the country. And I called the defeat of Helmut Kohl. And I'm calling the defeat of the Republicans in the year 2000. They're finished.

MR: Okay, we have it on tape now.

JH: They're done. So whoever hears it here, they can harken back to that and see it. They killed themselves in the attempt to dislodge a duly elected president — on a scurrilous at best and morally filthy at worst — matter that they had no business spending such time, and money — $50 million, in excess of $50 million.

MR: What kind of positive changes do you see, if that election goes the way you think it will, in our country? Or what do you think needs to be changed?

JH: Well the people, the politicians sent to represent the people, have got to get back to representing the people and not the business entities that pay them. For them to sell their vote to the businesses and abrogate the promises to the people, that's got to stop. That systematic betrayal of the trust of the people has got to stop. That has got to stop because we are now in a world where we are the minority. You see, as an American Negro person whose grandfather was a slave, I remember constantly being told that we are a minority and we have no power. But when you look at the world, only three tenths of the world's population are unpigmented. Seven tenths of the world's population are pigmented people. And in this so-called global society the once dominant force is now a minority force. And that's got to change everything. We see it changing in our own country. You know, demographics have changed. And so mankind has got to be what mankind was created to be: a brother and a sister to every other living thing. This has got to make

changes in religion, the idea of churches representing intercession between man and God, that's got to go. The churches are finished. I think this is the end, in this century, of all churches, including the Roman Catholic church.

MR: That's an interesting comment, because you, yourself, I remember when we last spoke, it was almost five years ago, you described yourself as a very spiritual person.

JH: Oh yes.

MR: But it's not something that you need the church for.

JH: Well I grew up in the church. I grew up in the African Methodist Episcopal church. But I watched the church abuse my father you know. They worked him until he dropped dead. They didn't reward him for the work that he did, they just used him to build up other churches then they would award these other churches that he had built up to others who had done nothing. It's like our political system, like a business promotional system. And I watched all this. And so I realized that churches represent the intercession between the spirit of man and the force that created him, which we may call God or we can call it Allah or we can it Brahmin or Vishnu or whatever name we give it. It's that force that created us. Because show me a man that made me a man and then I'll worship him. But until then I will worship He who made man. And so it is that force that the church tries to pretend to be and never is. So the whole system has got to change. You have to fall on your knees and speak to God yourself. Each of us has to become a priest and be his own church, and morally lift ourselves up so we don't think of doing harm to anybody else. Harm comes first from thought you know. You think of doing harm to someone, then you do something. But if you think about yourself and about who you are and your place in the world, you're not going to do anybody any harm.

MR: Has there been times in your life when you have felt your own spirituality has suffered and your life has suffered because of it? And then you changed?

JH: No I don't think that my life has ever suffered because of my spirituality. What I think has happened is that I have transgressed my own spiritual beliefs. I have lied. I have committed adultery. I have ingested drugs of various kinds. These are crimes against your spirit. And I have committed such crimes. And so my spirituality hasn't been the cause of any illness or wrongfulness. My own actions have done that, as it does with everyone. Every act you commit you pay for. It's like a movie theater. When I was a kid I couldn't get in that movie until I paid a dime. I had to pay the dime to get in. It's the same in this life. We're all in a movie.

MR: Literally.

JH: I always say, people say, "you look great for 78" you know. "How do you feel?" I say I feel just like I feel when I went to the movies. I'm not leaving until this movie ends.

MR: Man I hope it's a double feature for you.

JH: But I think that's the way life is you know. If you're interested in life and you're into life, you'll live forever. Because I think, as the ancient Greek philosopher said, "we do not die, we kill ourselves." Man as a creative being, if you examine him, he's made to last eternally. There's no malfunctioning in the original construction of the human anatomy. The body is made to last forever. We kill it with what we do. And so I try to do as little to my body of an inimical nature, as I possibly can, and I'm still working on that. Because I like sugar and sugar is poison. I like ice cream — too much milk is bad for the system. I'm always running up against it. How come it tastes so good? I'm still about six years old when it comes to that. You know all this talk of knowledge, when it comes to what you really want you're an ignoramus.

MR: Well you have to have a few challenges to build your character you know — for something to work on.

JH: I suppose. Well I know that's true. That's true.

MR: Well gosh I know a lot has happened to you since the last time we spoke. You just finished an engagement with Annie Ross?

JH: Yeah.

MR: At the Blue Note.

JH: Yeah, that's a phenomenon I'm very happy I lived to see because being in show business, since seven, there are things that you see that you expect to see. You expect it if you do well in your act, people will give you applause and they'll love you and they'll want you to come back. This you expect. But I never saw what happened when Annie Ross and I got back together. And that is, the minute we were introduced and walked on stage, the whole house stood up and applauded for 12-15 minutes. And I never saw this in my whole life. This was quite something. And I still am at a loss to say what it is, really. Because I don't want to overpraise what is happening but I don't want to underpraise it either. I think it's a validation of the fact that in creating words for big band arrangements — which is what Leonard Feather dubbed "vocalese" — I stumbled upon a new cultural art form. And this attitude of these people who stand up when we walk on is validation of that. It gives it its bona fides you know. I did something.

MR: It sure did, and it lasted. I mean that music has been out there for some 40 years now, and hit on different generations, and I think people responded to the quality and the longevity of it, and thus that kind of ovation.

JH: Yeah. And I was also heartened and kind of amazed, because it both exhilarated Annie and me, but brought to my attention something that I try not to pay too much attention to which is age — the fact that I was entertaining three generations. People came with their

grown sons and daughters and their children's records. They all had the albums. See it was three generations looking at us: grandpa and grandma, who were the big hard core fans forty years ago; their sons, 24, 25, out of college you know with their wives; and their kids, with the albums. And I said how old does that make me? It's amazing. It really takes your breath away. It starts you to thinking, good Lord, that's quite something. I think that's really interesting. Well you know Duke did that too. He told me about that — where he'd meet these kids at these proms and they would say, "my grandfather said he first heard you — ." And Duke would say "oh that was my son."

MR: That was my son. Well when you look in jazz history there's a small number comparatively of real innovators. There's people that build on the innovations. I think that you're one of those small number of innovators and gosh, you can take a great deal of pride in that.

JH: Well it's delicate for me because you must be aware of egoism. Egoism — or is it egotism — I don't know if there's a "t" in there or not, and I'm an English major I should know. But anyway you must beware of the ego, the overactivity of the ego. Because man nothing is done alone. If it hadn't been for King Pleasure, for Eddie Jefferson, for Annie Ross' "Twisted" and "Farmer's Market" which were done before Lambert, Hendricks & Ross, I would not have had the road sign to point me toward lyricizing orchestral versions of things. You have to watch out. Whereas it's true that what Leonard Feather dubbed vocalese was the lyricizing of orchestral things — without that lyricizing of individual horn parts, I doubt if I would have been able to do what I did. I had a lot of help in that. Just as everything else. Everybody has help. Edison never acknowledged the help he had from Tesla. In fact there are some people who say he stole the light bulb from Tesla, as there are facts to support that. But you have to be aware of how you assess yourself, because you can go overboard and you can obscure the contributions of those who came before you. You can stand in their light if you're not careful. I don't want to do that.

MR: Right.

JH: I don't want to do that. I'm very aware that if it hadn't been for these people I may never have done what I did.

MR: Well even Ellington had his influences, and that kind of pulled a lot of things together to make his sound.

JH: I was surprised when he told me that all he wanted to have was an orchestra that would approach Fletcher Henderson's. I said whoa.

MR: I think he did that.

JH: Yeah, I think he did. But I mean that's what he wanted. He just wanted to approach Fletcher's orchestra. That makes you want to go back and listen to Fletcher again. But

that was a clean band. They were beautiful. And Jimmie Lunceford's too, he also admired Jimmie Lunceford's band, because they dressed well. I saw them one time in Toledo in a show — they had three costume changes. They opened up in white tails, they came back in the middle in orange tuxedos, and they closed in light tan tuxedos. Great show band, it was really fantastic. A really good looking outfit too, and entertaining, very entertaining.

MR: Well let me take you back just for a few moments. You told me some marvelous stories about your childhood and how you got by — I don't know if you recall, you talked about singing in front of the juke box, and you had a huge family, is that correct?

JH: Yeah.

MR: What kept all of you together in some of the hard times?

JH: Well it was love, it was just love. My father and my mother — my mother had 17 children all together. Two died and 15 survived, 12 boys and 3 girls. And she did all the laundering and washing up and cleaning and everything, until the girls got old enough to be of help to her. You know they don't make them like that anymore. Those women were hearty in those days, and not just my mother but almost every other women was the same, they would do it. They were cooking three meals a day for their families, they were washing and ironing all the clothes everybody wore, they were keeping the house cleaned, it was amazing how much work those women did in those days. It was amazing. I look back and I can never remember my mother sleeping. When I got up, no matter how early I got up in the morning to get ready for school, my mother was there with the breakfast, on her feet. And the last thing I remember at night coming home from the night clubs where I'd go and work was my mother sitting in front of the fire, still in her apron, getting a little nap, nodding. And I would wake her up by putting this change into her apron. And the weight of the change would wake her up. And that would be about two o'clock in the morning. And she'd wake up and fix me something before I went to sleep, to get up at seven to go to school the next morning. And every day this was, every day.

MR: That's a great story. You were playing as a young man, not even in your teens yet or were you in your —

JH: I was about 11, 12 years old.

MR: What kind of work were you able to do or allowed to do in the clubs?

JH: Well I worked for the local gangsters, the Licavolian mob ran Ohio and part of Illinois. And the Purple Gang ran southern Michigan and the Detroit area. So Michigan was wet and Ohio was dry. So the Licavolis would run liquor down from Michigan into Ohio, into Toledo. And they had this place called the Chateau La France which was a night club that featured a floor show with Art Tatum and me, and I was 11. And the guys that ran the

liquor that rode shotgun for the trucks, one Packard convertible and another one in the back, there was two guys in front and two in back with sawed off shotguns. They would drive into the back of the club, and we were not allowed in the front of the club. You know Art Tatum and I could entertain the people but then we had to go back into the kitchen area. And back there it was rougher you know. And beside the door there was a barrel and I wondered, what was that barrel. So these guys would come off a run and they'd drive this car back up and park it under the trees out there, and come in the back door with these big overcoats on and the big Borsalino hats and they'd pull these sawed off shotguns out from their coats and put them in this barrel. And I'm watching this. I couldn't believe it. It was like watching a Warner Brothers movie.

MR: Here we go, you're still in a movie.

JH: Well to me everything's a movie. And I was fascinated, I couldn't believe it. And they would come by where I was standing and they'd say, "hi, kid," and they'd rub my head you know, which was so demeaning. Because the actual statement was you can always rub a nigger's head for luck. That was the prevailing statement. So when they did that I'd get so mad. And then they'd put something in my hand, and then when they went I'd be angry. I'd look in my hand, and there's ten dollars. That would feed my family of 15 for a week. So I'd get a lot less angry. I became philosophical through going through things like that. I would get angry but then I would say, hey if they didn't do that, what would you do.

MR: Yeah. We're going to take a little break here and we'll get our tea. That's amazing.

JH: But it was just everyday life to us, that's just what went on. And actually in a lot of ways it was much more picturesque than it is now because there were no illusions about it. Everybody knew what was happening. Now everything is dressed up under a façade and actually the same thing is happening. The gangsters are functioning and they're functioning because the politicians are helping them, the judges are helping them, and it's all hidden beneath some kind of mask. Earl Gray — oh I hate it when they do that, they put the milk in a glass. It's going to be all over the saucer and the table. Why do they do that? I think I'll spoon it out. I hate hotel service. Very seldom do they give you service.

MR: They should have the people that make this stuff up sit and do this. So they know the kind of thing they're giving people to deal with.

JH: Put it in one of those little pitchers you know, so that you could pour it into the — and have a teapot. Well you know tea should be in a pot. The British know how to do this. Look at it already. I lived in London for five years with my family. Boy they do tea. Where are we, 61st?

MR: Yeah, between 61st and 62nd I think we are.

JH: Where is the Stanhope? It's Fifth Avenue across from the Metropolitan Museum. What street is that, 81st isn't it? But anyway they do an English tea that's outasite. It's real. I'll have to clean this up.

MR: I'll follow your lead here.

JH: Yeah that's the best way. Because if you try to pour it it's going to be all over the saucer. I just watched three of the Miss Marple movies with Margaret Rutherford. Did you ever see those things? You should buy those, those are great. They're made with MGM money that they earned in England, and at that time you couldn't take it out so they started making movies over there, and they found this Margaret Rutherford woman who had been a Vaudevillian for years, and she was kind of past her prime so they cast her as Miss Marple. Oh man, she's too much. She is too much, this lady. And they're well written, and they're very good stories, and they make a very entertaining movie. So I bought all three of them and I screened them all day yesterday. Really good. And they used the best English actors, like one of them was with Robert Morley, who is a favorite of mine, and another one is with Lionel Jeffries, and another one was Arthur Kennedy who was very good. But Margaret Rutherford, big, wide woman — ugly as homemade sin but funny as hell. I'm also trying to get —

MR: Can we put this over here?

JH: Sure. I'm also trying to get a transcript of the screenplay to "Lawrence of Arabia" by Robert Bolt. Best screenwriting in the history of film. It's so beautiful, the language. I don't know how many times you've watched that movie.

MR: A couple of times I've seen it, yeah.

JH: Watch it again and just listen to the language, don't pay too much attention to the visuals, which is hard because they're superb too. But listen to the language, it's incredible to think a guy wrote this. It's fantastic. It's literature of the highest order. Robert Bolt. Boy.

MR: Well let me just pick up — was it a point of conversation in your family that Jon is working in a nightclub?

JH: Oh, yeah, Jonny was able to earn money in a nightclub. My father never saw me. My mother never saw me, because they sold liquor in nightclubs and they would never go. But I sang at banquets at times and they would come and they would see me. But my father won a car in the 30s when nobody had a car, and wouldn't go into the movie house to get the car, because that is forbidden in the Bible.

MR: I'm not following you on that.

JH: Well places of amusement are forbidden for the followers of the Word to go to. So in order to get the car he had to go there and present the ticket, and he wouldn't go, he would not do it, he would not go. And one of my brothers was older, 22 or something, he

says, “that’s stupid.” And my father knocked him down. He said, “get upstairs and go to bed,” he says, “I’m a grown man,” and he says, “you’re in my house.”

MR: I guess he had his priorities in order.

JH: Oh yeah. Oh he was something. I saw him stand up to a sheriff down south with a gun on his hip during the days when there were people being lynched every day. And he physically pulled the sheriff up out of his chair.

MR: For an insult?

JH: No he had pushed us off of two wooden planks into the mud because this guy wanted he and his wife to pass. And so my brother and I stood on one of the planks to let them by. He said, “get off this sidewalk.” You know, “get all the way off.” And I said, “why? There’s room for you to pass.” He says, “oh you’re one of those smart niggers huh?” I was visiting then from Toledo down in Kentucky. So he went and got the sheriff. And the sheriff pushed us into the mud. So we went home and told our father, and he took us down to the sheriff’s office and said, “sheriff, I want to talk to you.” And he says, “yeah, Reverend, just a minute,” and he kept writing you know. My father stood there about five minutes and he said, “sheriff I want to talk to you.” He said, “I heard you Reverend,” he says, “just wait a minute.” So my father picked him up. My father was a big man, and stood him up. And the sheriff was startled. And we’re waiting for him to reach for his gun or something, and he says, “all right, what is it Reverend?” And my father says, “don’t ever put your hands on my children.” And the sheriff says, “all right, all right Reverend.” It was unbelievable. I couldn’t understand that. How could he do that? But he did it, and it went smooth, and nothing happened. My father had an aura and an authority about him that people immediately respected. When he died, by that time I had married an Irish girl. When he died I took my wife to the funeral. And when I drove into town the town was buzzing, because it was in Kentucky. And they stopped me a couple of times and says, “whatchall doin’ here boy?” And they’re looking at my wife. And I says, “I’m Jon Hendricks, I’m here for my father’s funeral, Reverend Hendricks.” And they said, “oh Reverend Hendricks, okay.” And I went to the funeral. It was incredible. And at the funeral, half the town was there, and fully half of the people in the church were white people. That’s how respected my father was. And I remember sitting with him one night and there was a local white preacher who used to come over in the evenings and sit and talk to my father. They would be sitting in these rocking chairs on the porch. And one night the preacher says, “Reverend I just wanted to discuss something with you.” And my father says, “what was that?” He said, “well I just can’t help it,” he said, “I just feel that my people are better than your people.” And the rocking kept on, and I’m waiting. And my father said, “well Reverend,” he said, “do you believe in God?” And so the white

preacher said, “well you know I do.” And my father said, “well then what’s your problem?” And the rocking kept on. And not another word was spoken. And I said whooooh. He got right to the heart of the matter. Because that’s the key. We still talk about a problem. There is no problem. There is no racial problem if you acknowledge God. Because if you acknowledge God then you are looking at another child of God. So what are you talking about? If you’re going to separate from that other child of God because of this mythical term you have here, you are acting in an ungodly way. So when people ask me about race, I say, “what time does it start?”

MR: Well said.

JH: Well you know there is no such thing — there is just mankind, that’s all there is on this planet. You will only find mankind, that’s it, that’s the highest form of life you’re going to find here. And He looks like every type of thing you can imagine. In every part of the world He looks different. But He eats the same foods. And He has a way of wrapping the meat in some kind of a dough, that’s called a tortilla or a blintz or a crepe. But it’s still wrapping meat in dough. Every where you go He does this.

MR: He had a big box of crayons.

JH: Exactly. This is ridiculous, this paying attention to this problem. I believe if you talk about the problem you are the problem. And you see these well meaning people I’m sure, talking about race, they are the problem. Because they have separated man from man, and now they’re going to solve the way to try to get them back together. First they’ve separated them with their own voices in their own words, and then they’re going to try to get them back together? How are they going to do that? They create an insolvable problem, when all they have to do is treat everybody like they would want to be treated themselves. Just like Christ and everybody else said — and then they’ll be the first to tell you, “oh it’s very complex.” It’s complex because they have this evil in their heart that they have no intention of getting rid of. That’s the complexity. It’s not complex. It’s simple.

MR: You know I wish we could clone you.

JH: Send in the clones. Forgive me.

MR: I set it up, you picked up.

JH: I can’t resist a straight line.

MR: Well you had mentioned Detroit.

JH: Detroit.

MR: Detroit and seeing Diz and Charlie Parker there. And didn’t Charlie Parker tell you to pursue music or something like that?

JH: Well we had this bandstand conversation. I think we covered this in our last interview but I'll go over it again.

MR: I'm not sure.

JH: We had this quick bandstand conversation. I had all his records when I came out of the Army. I had heard "Salt Peanuts" on the ship. I had won $300 shooting craps on the boat, and I heard this record from the ship's radio room [scats]. I said whoa. Because it was in my head already from my Art Tatum days. And you know I heard Art Tatum, so I ran up to the radio room and I said to the guy, "what's that record you just played?" Because by that time he's playing something else. He said, "I don't know it's down there on the floor." And I looked down and the floor's covered with records. I says, "what kind of a label was it?" He says, "it had a red label." So I looked down there and finally I found this Musicraft red label thing called "Salt Peanuts." I says, "hey, is this it?" And he was talking on the radio, and then he says, "yeah, that's it — Salt Peanuts, with Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker." So I gave him 25 bucks and I said, "play this for the next hour." And so he played this record — drove everybody crazy on the ship. People came up to the radio, "what the hell is that? Play something else?"

MR: Forget it, man, I've got 25 bucks.

JH: But I couldn't believe that and so I says whoa, man. So when I landed in Baltimore I immediately went to the nearest record shop and the guy told me where I could find Bird and Diz's records. Because they weren't sold in the respectable music shops. You had to go to the little dedicated jazz people to buy these records. So I bought as many of them as I could get my hands on and I bought anything that had to do with bebop, and bought Dave Lambert and Buddy Stewart. Because at that time in the store you could go in a little booth and you could play the records to see if you wanted to buy them. And I bought everything I could get my hands on that had to do with bebop. I had a whole cardboard box full of these 78s. Because when I heard that I heard what I had heard when I was 14, 15 with Art Tatum. You know I worked with him for two years at the Waiter's & Bellman's Club. And Art was the father of bebop — you know the chord substitutions and the speed with which he played, and the tempo changes. Especially the advanced harmonics — the 9th and 13th chords. I had heard all that then. So by the time I got to Toledo, I was the only cat into that. Everybody was where we had left off, you know, Lunceford, Basie, Ellington, they were still there. But I was into this — they said, "what is this stuff?" And I turned a lot of musicians in Toledo on to Bebop, as I'd invite them over to listen to my records. So when Bird came, somebody, it was my first wife, she said, "you know my husband scats and he'd like to scat with you." So Bird said, "yeah, yeah, well send him up." So I went up and they were doing "The Song Is You." And

Kenny Dorham had just replaced Miles. So Bird had finished playing and he told me, so that I scatted. I scatted about ten choruses. I didn't know when to stop. I was looking for a place to stop.

MR: Someone jump in here.

JH: So finally I said that's enough, you'd better stop, so I quit. And Kenny Dorham got up from his chair next to Bird and he was starting to play his solo, and I started to leave the bandstand. And I felt this tug on my coattail. I'm trying to leave, and this — and I look and there's Bird and he's got ahold of my coattail, and so I turned back. You know I've been in show business all my life so I made it look like I'd just changed my mind, because of the audience. So I turned back and he says to sit in the chair next to him. So I sit there, you know Max is playing, Curly Russell is plucking, the piano player was Al Haig, he's chording, and the music is going on, and Kenny is soloing. And so Bird is looking out at the audience, and I'm over here and he says, "hey man, what do you do?" I said, "I'm a law student." And he looks at me. "A law student?" I said, "yeah." He says, "man, you ain't no lawyer." I said, "oh yeah, what am I?" He says, "you're a jazz singer." I said, "so what do I do about that?" I'm condescending to him, I'm humoring to him. And he says, "well, you've got to come to New York." So I thought New York, 13 million people. A million people a day pass through there. I said, "I don't know anybody in New York." He says, "well you know me." I said, "well where will I find you?" He says, "just ask anybody." So I figured to myself, I says this guy's nuts. And so then I get up to leave and I says, "thanks." He says, "not at all." He says, "you know when you get to New York look me up." I say, "okay." And I was trying to get out of there. So I got off the bandstand, my knees were shaking, and I was thinking what kind of cat is that? Just ask anybody. Whoa. So I forgot it. Because I was into my studies and I was into local politics at that time and I was attracting a lot of attention from the local politicians because I was getting a 3.5 average, I had the highest grades in the pre-law college. So they were all tapping me for going into politics and all that. So I was busy with a lot of stuff and I was trying to make a living and I had a son by that time, a young boy, he was three years old. So I'm trying to support my family and I didn't think about anything like what he said. So two years and four months went by. And I got involved in the local legal scene around there and found that it was very racist. And they were not going to put me in the position that I had earned. By getting the 3.5 average, the highest grades, you immediately inherit the job of juvenile state probation officer, that's the way it's been awarded for 20 years previously. The highest graded pre-law student got that job. So when they awarded it to me, it meant that I would be on a social equal with all the juvenile court judges and their wives. And my wife was Irish. And this was 1948. And

that is not done. But I never paid any attention to those things. I truly never paid attention to any of that stuff. So here I was in this situation where they had sent a guy to my house and he told me he says, "Jon, you've got to withdraw your name." I said, "why? I earned it, are you kidding? I earned that." He says, "look, if you insist on this, they're going to lean on me, and you know I've got a wife and two kids." I said, "okay." So I said hum, that means I'm not going anywhere in Toledo, however brilliant I am, I am going nowhere in that society. That's the notice they served on me. So I'd been singing at night, I was singing and playing drums, and doing very well at that too. So I says I think I'll go somewhere where I'll have more freedom. So I figured maybe I'd go to Canada, that's the end of the underground railroad, it's much more liberal there, that'd be a good place for my family. So I went to the Canadian border and they asked me did I have a thousand dollars in cash on me. I said no, I've only got three hundred. They said, "well you have to have a thousand if you're going to immigrate into Canada." I said, "I don't have a thousand, I have three hundred." They said, "well you can't do it." So they turned me away at the border. So I figured I'll go to New York, and that guy Charlie Parker, I'll look him up. So on the way to Buffalo from the border, my old Chevy broke down. Conked out. So I get a ride into the city, and I just left the car because it was finished. And I got on the Greyhound bus and went into New York. And I got off at the bus station and I remembered Joe Carroll in Toledo was singing with Dizzy, which was my gig, I was supposed to be Dizzy's first singer. But I had moved from Rochester back to Toledo and he had come to Rochester looking for me and couldn't find me and hired Joe Carroll. So I called Joe and I said, "where is Bird?" He said, "The Apollo Bar, 125th Street and Seventh Avenue." I almost dropped the phone. This was two years and four months later. I said whew.

MR: He was right, anybody would know where he is.

JH: I said good Lord. So I put my wife in a hotel and that night I went over to this club and I walked in there and Gerry Mulligan was on the bandstand with his red hair and his red beard, he had this Ming the Merciless — remember this character Ming the Merciless in Flash Gordon?

MR: Yes, with the thing.

JH: With this long goatee. That's the way Gerry had this long, red beard and a shock of red hair. And jeans, no socks and tennis shoes. That was how he was dressed on the bandstand. Well those guys were spending all their money on heroin. They were shooting up all day every day. And he was living uptown with Bird at that time. And Roy Haynes was on drums, Curly Russell was on bass, and Bud Powell was on piano. So they were playing "The Song Is You," the song that I scatted with him as I went by. And as I

walked past the bandstand, now it had been two years and four months since I had seen him for about nine minutes on this bandstand in Toledo, which is the heart of nowhere. And as I walked past the bandstand, he's playing [scats], "hey Jon, how you doin' man, you want to sing some?" I almost fainted. It took my breath away. I said good Lord, who the hell is that? I couldn't believe that. And after the set he came over to my table, sat down, talked to me and just said, "what you doing?" And I said, "well I just got here." He says, "well I told everybody about you." And he had. I had no trouble making entree into the jazz scene. Miles knew me, Dizzy knew me, all the cats knew me. Kenny Dorham knew me because he was there in Toledo. So I had the best PR man in the world. So I came in, I just slid in. It was amazing. And that's how I got my start in New York. He really did talk about me, and some of the cats told me, or Dizzy told me Bird told him, "man there's a bad cat in Toledo."

MR: What a great story.

JH: And I only saw him about three more times. Because he was running in the netherworld I called it, because it was a world of trying to get high, trying to get ahold of some horse or some money to get some horse, and to shoot up and all that, and I was not interested in that so I never really spent a lot of time with him. I would see him and his first concern would be, "how are you? How is everything? Is everything all right? Do you need anything?" He's asking me if I need anything. And he's looking for some dope and didn't have any money himself, but he's asking me if I need anything. Amazing.

[phone ring]

MR: Pause for the phone.

JH: Amazing man. I really thought about him until I hit upon just how amazing he was, and it stopped me. I want to tell you about that.

MR: I can't believe how fast this time has passed.

JH: Oh it did that last time. We seem to talk about 15 minutes and it was gone. When it's interesting it goes. When it's not interesting it stands still.

[phone call]

JH: The whole seasonal pattern that we lived with all of our lives and all of our parents' lives, is going to change. Places that were hot are going to be cold, places that were cold are going to be hot, and I think that's what this stuff means — snow in the south, snow in Jerusalem. So I think the whole earth is shaking off this last thousand years. I think that's what it does every thousand years, just like a dog when he jumps in the water, when he comes out he goes — that's what the earth is doing, and it's going to shake off all these politicians. I believe it in my soul you know, because I think that's what it means. I think

a person is wise if he watches things cosmically instead of locally. Try to go up into the sun and look down at the earth. Then you can see it a lot better. You see it a lot.

MR: Are we still rolling kind of?

TH: Yes. And you can tell Monk now —

MR: Oh, what did Louis say?

JH: Oh Louis asked me what it was and he's just worried about getting ripped off, like all jazz musicians. And I said no, no, no, this is archival. That means 50 years from now students will be able to walk into Hamilton and say, "that's Louis Hayes. He was a great drummer." And I told him, what do you think I'm doing here. You know I'm doing mine now. And he said, "okay, tell Monk I'll do it."

MR: Oh thank you.

JH: Yeah they just want to make sure they don't get ripped off.

MR: Yes I know and it's not the first time it's happened and I appreciate you being my Charlie Parker.

JH: Ken Burns' show is coming out this year. I'm in that.

MR: Great.

JH: Yeah they came to my house and taped all day. He's a beautiful guy. What a gift to television that guy is.

MR: I guess.

JH: Wow. And what a spirit. His "Civil War" is the first time they ever told the story of the war from the standpoint of what it was really about. It was about are you going to hold slaves or are you not going to hold slaves. That's what it was about. They talk about it was the industrial north against the agricultural south. Baloney. It's a matter of are you going to own a human being or are you going to understand that you can't do that. That's what it's about.

MR: Isn't it ironic or I'm not sure what the word is, that you had a whole nation going to war over that issue and we still have a problem. And maybe as you said there's a simpler way to deal with it than we have been.

JH: Well if you listen to those people, they always invoke God. And that's because they don't believe in God. The people who believe in God you never hear them say His name. It's the ones who have no belief in any God that are always talking about — as God as my judge. It's like when Eisenhower was talking to Nikita Khrushchev, you know the *New York Times* printed a whole transcript of that on two pages, two full pages of the *New York Times*. And I always read the *Times* for that reason. If I want to know what someone said, I don't read the front page story because you don't get the real story there. I read the transcript. And in this transcript Khrushchev said well you've been lying to us, you said

you didn't spy on us and we shot down your U-2, we have your Francis Gary Powers. And Eisenhower said well don't tell me that you people don't spy on us. And Khrushchev said as God is my judge, we have sent no planes over your territory. He says we know who you are and we know how much you dislike us. We don't have to spy on you to find out about it. And Eisenhower says well it's funny you should speak of God, when everybody knows you're atheist. And Khrushchev says we are not atheistic. We just don't believe in those black-robed beggars.

MR: Oh, I have never heard that before.

JH: That's right. That was in the *New York Times* in the transcript. You didn't hear that, did you? He says as God as my judge, Eisenhower says you don't believe in God, he says we do believe in God, he says, we don't believe in those black robed beggars. And it's the truth. And average westerner supports his supposed belief in God by citing that church. And that church is about as far away from any God as you're ever going to get on this planet. You understand? That's where all that oratory and invocation of the name of God comes in, because it has nothing to do with God. It's got to do with people who have no belief in God. Because the first thing you do when you believe in God is shut up. Keep silent and know that I am God. That's the injunction.

MR: Well as usual you have given me about a month's worth of food for thought at least.

JH: Yeah we need food for thought. Boy can we use some of that. That's true. But I was going to tell you about Charlie Parker.

MR: Yeah.

JH: So I became very curious about this cat, because he was so beautiful as a person. I mean he showed such great compassion and such true concern, beyond all the other musicians that I had met. And I was wondering, this guy, there's more to him than meets the eye. Then I used to hang out uptown with the songwriters on 50th Street and Broadway. So I ran into Teddy Reig one day. So we got to talking about Bird. Teddy Reig used to sell bass drum beaters. That was his thing that he sold. And he made the first records with Bird and Diz, "Salt Peanuts" and all. So we got to talking about Bird and he says, "man this cat" he says, "when we did 'Cherokee — '" [scats] He says, "when we did that, we didn't have any money and this was the last date so we took it to the publisher to get the license to it and the publisher said it's a desecration of Ray Noble's composition and we're not going to give you the license." So they couldn't release the whole thing because they needed that song to complete. Those records they made in those days, they didn't have any extra songs like they do now. So he says, "oh man," and they were devastated because they couldn't get their money back until they put the product out on the market. So he took it to Bird. He says man, what are we going to do? And right away,

without any hesitation, Bird says, "change the title, just call it "Ko-Ko.'" He says, "Cocoa, you mean the drink?" He says, "no 'Ko-Ko.'" And you think that'll work? Bird says, "why not?" You know the melody isn't defined anywhere. So they did it, and it was a big hit. And then Teddy Reig says, 20 years later he realized that "Ko-Ko" was the lord high executioner in the mythical kingdom of Titipu in Gilbert & Sullivan's "The Mikado," which took place in Mongolia. And Mongolians are the ancestors of all the American Indians and the Eskimos. They walked across the Bering Strait when it was connected. And the ones that stayed up in the north became the Eskimos and the ones that came down in the plains became the Indians. So that Ko-Ko was an ancestor of the Cherokees. Anthropologically. And Bird knew this right away. I said what a mind, what a mind. This guy, it's amazing, the range of his knowledge. They had a scene in the movie "Bird," where he goes up to the fenced estate of —

MR: Stravinsky, wasn't it?

JH: Stravinsky, yeah. Because that was his favorite composer. He was an intellectual, much more than a smoker of reefer or a shoot-up jazz musician, very much more depth to him than that. And this is the part of him that I want to cover. This was a very great man. Far greater than anybody realizes. And you only have to listen to one of his solos to hear the mental agility that inspired Coltrane and everybody else. Brilliant cat.

MR: Amazing. You've got some great news regarding your vocalese school?

JH: Oh yeah. I'm waiting for my federal papers to come back, and then the University of Toledo has engaged me to start in the fall, next fall, and I want to have the vocalese studies program start there. And from there we will proliferate all over the world. Because I've already made arrangements to have a rhythm section of Hank Jones, Ray Brown and Max Roach have all agreed to be the rhythm section for 2001.

MR: Gee you couldn't get anybody good.

JH: So jazz students from all over the world are coming to that school. Because I have students from all over the world asking me about studies. My singer, Kevin Burke, married a Japanese girl who now teaches with him. She came over her to study under me. And I told her I don't give personal lessons. So there's going to be students from all over the world coming to the University of Toledo when we start that program.

MR: Let me throw a little scenario at you here. You're in front of the college's Board of Trustees trying to pitch your idea. And as well meaning as they might be, they don't have a clue what vocalese really is.

JH: No, they don't.

MR: So what do you tell them?

JH: Well I tell them that the most popular exponents of it, therefore the best known, are the Manhattan Transfer. And they all say, "oh yeah, the Manhattan Transfer, oh yeah we know them." This is what happened around the table. And this one lady says, "oh I have all their albums." I said, "well do you have the album 'Vocalese'?" They said, "oh yeah, that was their biggest seller." I says, "yeah, I wrote that album."

MR: And everybody looks around —

JH: And then I tell them the story of the formation of the Manhattan Transfer. Their idea was to be a group like Lambert, Hendricks & Ross. That's why I helped them. That was their aim. I met Tim Hauser in a taxi. He was a taxi driver. And I got in his cab with my brother. And he says, "I know you, you're Jon Hendricks." I said, "how do you know me?" He says, "I know you. My name is Tim Hauser and my girlfriend Janis Siegel and I live in Brooklyn and we're going to start a Lambert, Hendricks & Ross type group called Manhattan Transfer." I gave him my card, and I said, "any time I can help you, let me know." And that was how they started. I said so that's what vocalese is. It's the setting of lyrics to established American jazz instrumentals in a form so that it tells a story with a beginning, a middle, an end, a plot, a cast of characters, the horns become the characters, and they make a commentary on the subject matter which is determined by the title. "Jumpin' at the Woodside" becomes a dissertation on a hotel where jazz musicians could stay and play at any time because there was nobody to complain because everybody staying there is also a jazz musician. So what do they care if you rehearse all night. They're probably rehearsing all night. So that's what that was. And each of the horn players makes some kind of comment on that. Buck Clayton has the trumpet solo, Lester Young a tenor solo, and Basie on piano. And all this has to work like an opera or like a well constructed theater piece, like a drama. Each person has to be a character within a previously defined plot structure, which is determined by the title. So it contains elements of theater, of literature, and above all, of poetry, and even above that, philosophy. So it's a completely new form, but it's based on the depths of the old established forms, mainly philosophy and poetry. Then they sit up and take notice.

MR: Yeah, right. You summed it up. That's great.

JH: Well I have to put this in the form of a syllabus, whatever that is.

MR: I have no doubt you'll manage. Well I hate to say this, your driver is waiting and —

JH: Serves him right.

MR: Serves him right. If I don't wear out my welcome I may come back and say Jon, how about part three?

JH: You can do that.

MR: Yeah?

JH: Yeah sure. I think these things are important. I think what you're doing is important. I think that younger students especially need to feel some contact with people they may never have seen in their lifetimes, but whom, if they're studying jazz, have an impact on them. That's the value of this. It's like a volume of history, but it's living history. These kinds of things are going to supercede history books. I don't think there'll be history books far into the future, especially if people write history as it occurs instead of waiting for years after the event has passed so that they can lie safely, you know, and also waiting until interest in it has waned. I think history should be written contemporarily, like you're doing with this. We should do the same thing politically. C-Span is actually doing that. C-Span is taking you into the House of Representatives, into the Senate, and showing you these great and noble souls that are supposed to defend the rights of you, the people. And what you get to see is just how little they do that, and how mealy mouthed they are about defending the rights of those who pay them, like the National Rifle Association and the tobacco interests and the National Association of Manufacturers. Those are their true sponsors and the people to whom they give their true worth as representatives of the people. And the people have seen this, have seen it over and over again. They've listened to Orrin Hatch try to justify the fact that he is humane enough to run for president while citing the fact that, "I have many Jewish friends — I have this 92-year old lady who is a Jewish lady, a very good friend of mine." The man killed himself. To any person listening and looking on, he killed himself. You condescending bastard. But he did it himself. Nobody else did it. And the people are watching them every day, kill themselves. The Republican party is dead. They're dead in the water. They don't even know it. If you blow on them, they'll fall down, bam. They are so decrepit, so inhumane, so out of touch with where people really are at. People who suffer from racism don't even want any more. They say come on, man. You know these kids today, they're saying hey come on man. Come on, let's get together, let's go. They're transcending all that stuff. That's garbage. That stuff is finished. But these people still think there's nobody looking at them, there's nobody listening to them. Look at Pinochet. Pinochet would have gotten off the English lords would have let him off. They had no documentary information. So what did they do? They punched up Uruguay on the internet, and there came all his crimes. The internet has abolished tyranny. Tyranny is finished. It's done.

MR: Because everybody will know about it.

JH: Everybody will know about it the minute you think of it. So we're living in a marvelous time here. And the changes are incalculable, and the ideas you have about everything are passe. Even whatever you can think of uttering, it's already passe, gone. Because you're

either going to go forward or you're going to go backwards. And if you go backwards you're going to fall off.

MR: Well, musician, and lyricist and philosopher and political analyst —

JH: And loud mouth.

MR: I want to thank you for a fascinating time again.

JH: Oh you're welcome.

MR: And best of luck with your school.

JH: Thank you.

MR: Great.